GAME CHANGERS

Gabe Newell built the store nobody wants to leave

Gamers will fight over consoles, GPUs and Linux, but never over Steam

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> The easiest way to stop piracy is not by putting antipiracy technology to work. It's by giving those people a service that's better than what they're receiving from the pirates.

I have been in the tech and gaming community for a long time, and every brand in it comes with fans, haters and critics. Apple has its cult, Nvidia has its price tags and Microsoft has its Start menu. If there is one company people unanimously love, it is Valve, and the love lives on Steam. Some people adore it so much that they skip the free games on Epic and pay for the same game on Steam. Free is the one price the internet cannot resist, and Steam still wins. That kind of loyalty should not exist for a company that takes a cut of nearly every PC game sold. The man behind it is Gabe Newell, who looks like a game studio boss and runs the most powerful shelf in gaming. He skips the keynotes, dodges interviews and still has more goodwill than any CEO who lives on stage. So how does a storefront end up with a fan club?

The Microsoft Exile

Newell spent about thirteen years at Microsoft working on Windows, which is a strange training ground for a man gamers now treat like a folk hero. Those years are the best clue to everything that followed, because Windows taught him how platforms win and how users resent them. In 1996 he and fellow Microsoft veteran Mike Harrington left to start Valve. Their first game, Half-Life, landed in 1998 and rewired the shooter. No cutscenes yanking you out of the action, just a scientist, a crowbar and a very bad day at work.

Valve noticed that fans were building better mods than most studios were building games, so it didn't sue them. It hired them. Counter-Strike began as a Half-Life mod, Team Fortress began as a Quake one and Dota grew out of a Warcraft III map. Newell's entire career runs on one instinct, that the people who love your thing should be working in it.

The storefront no one wanted

Steam launched in 2003 as a way to deliver patches, which sounds like the least exciting product ever shipped. Gamers hated it. When Half-Life 2 arrived in 2004 and demanded Steam to run, forums reacted as if Newell had taken their disc collections hostage. It is the same beat every beloved